

Curcuma zedoaria (Zingiberaceae) Zedoary

Description Perennial herb with large, tapering, elliptical leaves, pink or yellow flowers, and an aromatic, pale yellow root.

Habitat & Cultivation Zedoary is a common Indian and East Asian plant. It is cultivated in India, Bangladesh, Indonesia, China, and Madagascar.

Part Used Rhizome.

Constituents Zedoary contains a volatile oil, sesquiterpenes, curcumenone, curcuminol, and curdione. Curcuminol and curdione have cancer-fighting properties.

Medicinal Actions & Uses An aromatic, bitter digestive stimulant, zedoary is used in much the same way as ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155)—to relieve indigestion, nausea, flatulence, and bloating, and generally to improve digestion. The rhizome is used in China to treat certain types of tumors.

Research In trials carried out in China, zedoary was found to reduce cervical cancer, and increase the cancer-killing effects of radiotherapy and chemotherapy.

Related Species In Chinese herbal medicine, zedoary is often substituted for turmeric (*C. longa*, p. 90).

Cuscuta epithymum (Convolvulaceae)

Dodder, Hellweed, Devil's Guts

Description Leafless parasitic plant. Has threadlike stems, which are usually yellow-red in color, and small, scented, pale pink flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Dodder grows throughout Europe, Asia, and southern Africa. It prefers coastal and mountainous regions, and is gathered in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Dodder contains flavonoids (including kaempferol and quercetin), and hydroxycinnamic acid.

History & Folklore Dodder has always been an unpopular country plant. It is also known as hellweed and devil's guts, due to its tendency to overrun and strangle the plant on which it feeds. This host can be thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143), gorse (*Ulex europaeus*), or a crop such as beans. Dodder does, however, have medicinal benefits. In his *Materia Medica*, Dioscorides (1st century CE) notes its use in classical times in combination with honey to purge "black bile" and to lift a melancholy humor. In 1652, the herbalist Nicholas

Culpeper similarly recommended it "to purge black or burnt choler." Culpeper further states that dodder plucked off thyme is the most efficacious, making the interesting point that the parasite's medicinal benefits are determined in part by its host.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In line with its traditional use to purge black bile, dodder is still considered a valuable, though little-used, herb for problems affecting the liver and gallbladder. It is thought to support liver function and is taken for jaundice. Dodder has a mildly laxative effect, and is also taken for urinary problems.

Related Species Greater dodder (*C. europaea*) and flax dodder (*C. epilinum*) may be used in the same way as *C. epithymum*. *C. reflexa* is employed in Ayurvedic medicine to treat difficulty in urinating, jaundice, muscle pain, and coughs.

Cyanopsis tetragonoloba (Fabaceae)

Guar Gum

Description Erect annual growing to 2 ft (60 cm), with hairy 3-lobed leaves, small purple flowers, and fleshy seed pods.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Indian subcontinent, guar gum is cultivated extensively in India and Pakistan. The seed pods are harvested when ripe in summer.

Parts Used Pods, seeds.

Constituents Guar gum contains about 86% water-soluble mucilage, comprising mainly galactomannan.

History & Folklore Guar gum is a viscous substance made from ground guar seed mixed with water. It has been used as a filter in the mining industry, in paper manufacturing, and in cosmetics.

Medicinal Actions &

Uses Guar gum is an effective bulk laxative, similar in action to psyllium (*Plantago ovata*, p. 123). It delays the emptying of the stomach and thus slows down absorption of carbohydrates. As this appears to help stabilize blood-sugar levels, guar gum may prove useful in prediabetic conditions and in the early stages of type 2 diabetes. Research also indicates that guar gum lowers cholesterol levels. In Indian medicine, guar seed is a laxative and a digestive tonic.

Caution Do not exceed the dose. Guar gum can cause flatulence, abdominal distension, and intestinal obstruction.

Cydonia oblonga (Rosaceae)

Quince

Description Deciduous tree growing to 26 ft (8 m). Has green-grey oval leaves, pink or white flowers, and yellow, pear-shaped sweet-smelling fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to southwest and central Asia, quince has become naturalized in Europe, especially in the Mediterranean region. It grows in damp, rich soils in hedges and copses. The fruit is harvested when ripe in autumn.

Parts Used Fruit, seeds.

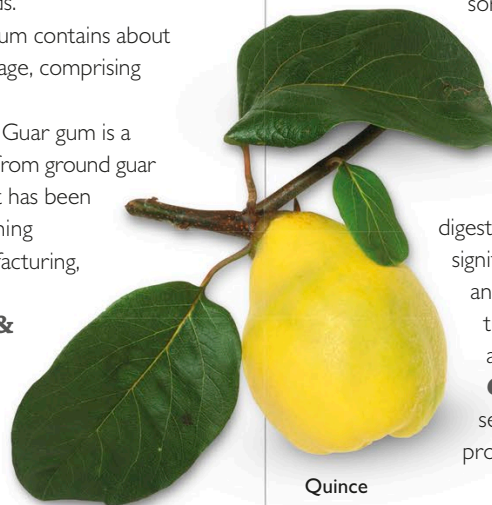
Constituents The fruit contains tannin, pectin, and fruit acids; the seeds contain about 20% mucilage, cyanogenic glycosides (including amygdalin), fixed oil, and tannins.

History & Folklore The quince has long been prized as a fruit and medicine in Greece and the eastern Mediterranean. It was used as an astringent in the time of Hippocrates (460–377 BCE).

Dioscorides (40–90 CE) records a recipe for quince oil, which was applied to itchy and infected wounds and spreading sores. In northerly climates, quince is often cooked to make a preserve. The English word "marmalade," meaning citrus fruit jam, comes from the Portuguese word for quince, *marmelo*.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The great astringency of the unripe fruit makes it useful as a remedy for diarrhea, one that is particularly safe for children. The fruit and its juice can also be taken as a mouthwash or gargle to treat canker sores, gum problems, and sore throats. When cooked, much of the fruit's astringency is lost; quince syrup is recommended as a pleasant, mildly astringent, digestive drink. The seeds contain significant quantities of mucilage and are helpful both in treating bronchitis and as a bulk laxative.

Caution Do not use the seeds except under professional supervision.



Quince

Cymbopogon citratus (Graminaceae)

Lemon Grass

Description Sweetly scented grass growing in large clumps up to 5 ft (1.5 m). Has narrow leaf blades and branched stalks of flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to southern India and Sri Lanka, lemon grass is now cultivated in tropical regions around the world.